

Behavioural Interviews

Behavioural questions relate specifically to a role's selection criteria such as communication skills, team work, customer focus and time management. An example of a behavioural question is 'Tell me about a time when you've had to deal with conflicting priorities.'

The theory behind behavioural questions is that if you have demonstrated a particular skill in one context, there's a possibility that this skill is transferable into another context - the job you're applying for. This means that skills gained in your studies, through your interests, extra-curricular activities or in the workplace could be very relevant to the vacancy.

Behavioural questions ask you to provide an example of a genuine past situation involving a specific behaviour. You need to state what your task was in that situation, how you performed that task, and the positive results of your actions in performing the task. If you then link your answer with one of the job requirements, that's even better! At first glance this might present a challenge, particularly if you're sitting in an interview and haven't prepared for behavioural questions.

This handout will give you some ideas on how to effectively meet this challenge. Interview practice is very important, and you'll need appropriate examples on which to base your answers.

What are the features of behavioural interview questions?

They often start with:
Tell me/us about a time when...
Can you think of a time where...?
Describe a situation where...

How do I answer behavioural interview questions?

The **STAR** formula is a useful method for answering behavioural interview questions,

'STAR' being an acronym for **S**ituation, **T**ask, **A**ction and **R**esult. This formula will also help you to address selection criteria in job applications, so it's a useful formula to remember.

Here's an example of a behavioural question and answer using the STAR formula:

Question: Tell me about a specific time when your verbal communication skills were on display.

Answer: Three months ago I became a member of a public speaking club to improve my presentation skills (**S**), and soon after was required to make my first short speech (**T**). I chose the topic 'water conservation'. I knew that other club members wanted to hear more about this topic because they'd been asking me about my Environmental Science studies degree and what I'd learned about water conservation. I made sure my talk had a clear beginning, middle and end and took along some photos to pass

around. Although I was nervous, I maintained eye contact with my audience, spoke without notes and finished right on the five-minute time limit **(A)**. The feedback I received was very encouraging; I've since made several longer speeches and am feeling a lot more confident about speaking in front of a group **(R)**. That's why I'm confident that I'd be able to make presentations as part of this job.

To practise answering behavioural questions, make a list of the selection criteria for the job and reflect on examples of achievements for each criterion, as follows:

Criterion – initiative

Example – improving a workplace procedure; suggesting an alternative assignment topic

Criterion – adding value

Example – exceeding sales targets; demonstrating excellent customer service to encourage repeat business

Etc...

One or more may be asked and it is best to avoid referring to the same situations/instances repeatedly.

Behavioural Vs non-behavioural interview questions

Behavioural questions are different from hypothetical questions, which focus on what you would do if a particular situation occurred. A question such as 'What would you do if you had to give a presentation and left your notes at home?' doesn't ask you to provide a specific example of when that happened and what you actually did.

A question such as 'What management style do you best respond to?' doesn't ask you to provide a specific example of when you've responded well to a particular management style.

Even so, employers appreciate examples, as these can provide evidence that you meet the selection criteria for the job. Even if a question isn't what you'd call a behavioural question, providing a credible example for each answer is good practice. Some behavioural questions can sound a little negative, in that they can ask about possible failures or conflicts you've experienced. For instance, you could be asked for an example of when you failed to meet a deadline or had conflict with a team member. Don't take the tone or content of these questions personally. They're often asked to determine whether you can learn from unfortunate situations and improve your skills. Workplaces need people who are willing to learn from their mistakes and as a result improve their own and the organisation's performance. Be prepared for this type of question and remember that in the workplace things don't go well all the time.

The key is to provide a credible example with a positive result in terms of what you've learned and/or improved. For example, you may have failed to meet an assignment deadline because you had several due at the same time, were required to work extra hours at your workplace and spent time coaching your brother for his half-yearly exams. This is a good example if you have a positive result such as creating and sticking to an improved study timetable, handing in the rest of your assignments early or on time and perhaps even improving your results! Examples must be your own and have some kind of 'happy ending', so if there isn't a happy ending, choose

Sample behavioural interview questions

- Describe a situation in which you were able to use persuasion to successfully convince someone to see things your way.
- Describe a time when you were faced with a stressful situation that demonstrated your coping skills.
- Give me a specific example of a time when you used good judgment and logic in solving a problem.
- Give me an example of a time when you set a goal and were able to meet or achieve it.
- Tell me about a time when you had to use your presentation skills to influence someone's opinion.
- Give me a specific example of a time when you had to conform to a policy with which you did not agree.
- Please discuss an important written document you were required to complete.
- Tell me about a time when you had to go above and beyond the call of duty in order to get a job done.
- Tell me about a time when you had too many things to do and you were required to prioritize your tasks.
- Give me an example of a time when you had to make a split second decision.
- What is your typical way of dealing with conflict? Give me an example.
- Tell me about a time you were able to successfully deal with another person even when that individual may not have personally liked you (or vice versa).
- Tell me about a difficult decision you've made in the last year.
- Give me an example of a time when something you tried to accomplish and failed.
- Give me an example of when you showed initiative and took the lead.
- Tell me about a recent situation in which you had to deal with a very upset customer or co-worker.
- Give me an example of a time when you motivated others.
- Tell me about a time when you delegated a project effectively.
- Give me an example of a time when you used your fact-finding skills to solve a problem.
- Tell me about a time when you missed an obvious solution to a problem.
- Describe a time when you anticipated potential problems and developed preventive measures.
- Tell me about a time when you were forced to make an unpopular decision.
- Please tell me about a time you had to fire a friend.
- Describe a time when you set your sights too high (or too low).